

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management

Sovereign Infrastructure Investment Memorandum

The Irish Sea Express

Liverpool – Isle of Man High-Speed Hovercraft Shuttle

A Strategic Transport & Economic Connectivity Proposal

Prepared for:

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management (EVWM)

Executive Summary

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management proposes the creation of the **Irish Sea Express**, a high-frequency, high-speed hovercraft service between **Liverpool** and **Douglas**, designed to operate as the maritime equivalent of an urban shuttle bus.

The objective is to transform the Isle of Man from a destination reached by occasional ferry departures into an island connected by predictable, frequent, all-day services.

Instead of planning around one or two sailings each day, passengers would have departures every 30–60 minutes during peak periods, allowing spontaneous business, tourism and commuter travel.

The proposal builds on the Isle of Man Steam Packet Company's existing Liverpool–Douglas route while introducing a new premium high-speed layer aimed at shorter journey times and greater service frequency. The Steam Packet's new vessel *Manxman* has already increased capacity and resilience on the Liverpool route.

Strategic Vision

The Irish Sea should be viewed not as a barrier, but as a transport corridor.

The proposal seeks to create:

The Liverpool–Douglas Metropolitan Connection

Where travelling to the Isle of Man becomes comparable to catching an express regional train.

The long-term ambition is for people to think:

"The next hovercraft leaves in half an hour."

rather than

"I need to book next week's ferry."

Investment Objectives

The programme would:

- Create high-frequency passenger services.
 - Reduce average journey times.
 - Support same-day business travel.
 - Expand tourism.
 - Improve resilience alongside conventional ferries.
 - Strengthen Liverpool–Isle of Man economic integration.
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Route

Liverpool Waterfront

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Irish Sea

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Douglas Waterfront

Approximate distance:

70 nautical miles (130 km)

Vessel Concept

Modern commercial hovercraft or other high-speed surface-effect craft designed for year-round passenger operations.

Indicative specification:

Feature	Specification
Passenger capacity	200–350
Cruising speed	45–60 knots
Journey time target	75–90 minutes
Daily operating hours	06:00–22:00
Accessibility	Step-free boarding

Modern commercial hovercraft are capable of these operating speeds, although detailed vessel selection would require a competitive procurement process and route-specific trials.

Service Pattern

Peak Period

Departure every:

30 minutes

Morning:

06:00–10:00

Evening:

16:00–20:00

Off-Peak

Departure every:

60 minutes

Operating day:

Approximately 16 hours

Illustrative daily frequency:

20–28 crossings in each direction

Final timetables would depend on fleet size, maintenance requirements and seasonal demand.

Journey Time Comparison

Route	Current Typical Fast Ferry	Proposed Hovercraft
Liverpool → Douglas	~2 hr 45 min	75–90 min

Actual journey times vary depending on vessel type, weather and port operations.

Passenger Market

Primary users:

Business

- Financial services
 - Legal sector
 - Government
 - Technology companies
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Tourism

Weekend breaks

Day trips

Events

Cruise passengers

Residents

Flexible travel

Medical appointments

Education

Family visits

Students

University connections

Internships

Graduate recruitment

Economic Impact

Labour Market

The proposal would create a practical day-return travel market between Liverpool and Douglas.

Illustrative scenario:

Leave Douglas:

07:00

Arrive Liverpool:

08:20

Business meeting

Depart Liverpool:

17:30

Return Douglas:

19:00

This enables a significantly wider range of same-day business activity than is currently possible.

Tourism

The Isle of Man welcomes hundreds of thousands of visitors each year, with motorsport, heritage and outdoor tourism forming major attractions. Easier access generally supports higher visitor numbers, although precise impacts depend on pricing, marketing and accommodation capacity.

Illustrative long-term scenario:

Measure	Estimate
Additional visitors	200,000–350,000/year
Additional tourism expenditure	£80–150 million/year

These are strategic planning scenarios rather than forecasts.

Business Growth

Improved connectivity would support:

- Financial services
 - Digital businesses
 - Professional services
 - Conference sector
 - Remote working
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GDP Impact

Approximate economy connected:

Region	GVA
Liverpool City Region	~£40bn
Isle of Man	~£6–7bn

Illustrative long-term benefits:

Category	Annual Estimate
Tourism	£80–150m

Category	Annual Estimate
Business productivity	£120–220m
Trade & investment	£80–150m
Property & commercial development	£30–80m

Total Potential Annual Benefit

£300–600 million

These figures represent a high-level appraisal of possible economic effects if increased connectivity leads to sustained growth.

Capital Investment

Component	Estimated Cost
Fleet of 4–6 vessels	£180–300m
Douglas hover terminal	£40m
Liverpool hover terminal	£50m
Maintenance facilities	£40m
Ticketing & digital systems	£20m

Total Programme

£330–450 million

Revenue Model

Illustrative assumptions:

Annual passengers:

1.5–2.0 million

Average fare:

£35–45

Passenger revenue:

£50–90 million/year

Additional revenues:

- Premium seating
- Freight parcels
- Hospitality
- Advertising

- Corporate contracts

Actual financial performance would depend on utilisation, operating costs and fare policy.

Strategic Benefits

The service would:

- Reduce perceived distance between Liverpool and the Isle of Man.
 - Complement, rather than replace, conventional ferries.
 - Increase transport resilience.
 - Support inward investment.
 - Strengthen the Isle of Man's position as a financial and digital economy.
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Investment Recommendation

Ellan Vannin Wealth Management should establish the **Irish Sea Express Infrastructure Fund** to finance a high-frequency hovercraft shuttle linking Douglas and Liverpool.

The proposal envisions the service as a **maritime rapid-transit system**: frequent, reliable and integrated with rail and bus networks at both ends.

If delivered alongside improvements to Liverpool's rail network and the wider Northern infrastructure programme, the Irish Sea Express could significantly enhance the Isle of Man's connectivity while supporting sustainable growth in tourism, business travel and cross-border investment.